

THE TALE OF YOUR WEEK
ISSUE NO. 4

The river

*Being a true account of Wren's week, Oct 22–28, as it was kept
by the Book, in 7 chapters.*





THU



FRI



SAT



SUN



MON



TUE



WED

A development sample. Wren's October is simulated. The photographs are real and were taken across several years. Photo keeps and Pagewright sheets were added for this sample after the saved nightly braids.

I want this one right at the front.

On Saturday, you wrote:

"the river, going gold"

Then on Sunday, you wrote:

"Sat with Amanda while she waited for news by the river."

I'm opening here. The rest is waiting inside.

THE CHAPTERS

CHAPTER THE FIRST · THURSDAY 22

In which you bought flowers for no one in particular before breakfast

CHAPTER THE SECOND · FRIDAY 23

In which you learned the name of the bakery cat after work

CHAPTER THE THIRD · SATURDAY 24

In which you oiled the squeaky kitchen door late at night

CHAPTER THE FOURTH · SUNDAY 25

In which you wore odd socks all day at the library

CHAPTER THE FIFTH · MONDAY 26

In which you tried a new route to work on the way home

CHAPTER THE SIXTH · TUESDAY 27

In which a few small things were kept

THE CHAPTERS, CONTINUED

CHAPTER THE SEVENTH · WEDNESDAY 28

In which a few small things were kept · Wednesday

IN THE ROOM



SERENITY



WICKER



PENNY



PROFESSOR



CHAPTER THE FIRST

In which you bought flowers for no one in particular before breakfast

Once upon a Thursday, under a waxing gibbous moon and the sky was clear, this is what happened.

Bought flowers for no one in particular before breakfast.

It was nearly dark by then.

12 days ago: Burned the toast and ate it anyway before breakfast.

Tonight I'm counting everything with a lid. So far it's eleven, and one of them is a cat.

Meanwhile, in the Labyrinth...

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE EAST STACKS

The Wrong Castle

The East Stacks grow a tower overnight.

You can see it from the Great Hall windows when the morning mist comes off: a thick dark finger standing where the library's east wing used to end. The bottom of it is *library*. It's got the right stone, the right narrow windows, the right smell of old glue. About halfway up, it changes its mind. There's a stretch of grey fortress wall with a flag on it that's no flag the Academy owns. And at the very top, as if the tower couldn't stop itself, there's a nursery window with yellow curtains and a wooden star hanging in the glass.

Between them runs a stair, and the stair keeps asking for another floor.

I can hear it from here. It's a slow soft *tick*, like a clock being wound. Each time the stair asks, the tower takes a stone from somewhere else and says yes.

A drawbridge hangs down over the Quillquarium. The nibs underneath are in a state. They've never agreed so completely, all thousand of them, in one long furious scribble, and the noise of it comes up through the floor like bees in a wall.

I've read about a tower like this one. It was in a book, and the book was careful, and the tower stayed in the book. It wasn't supposed to get out.

Penny's pinning up a notice on the foot of the stair. She does it with a drawing-pin and quite a lot of dignity:

THE EAST STACKS ARE SEVERAL PLACES. PLEASE USE ONE AT A TIME.

Permancer is tying ribbons to the banister, one at every third post, in a pattern he's clearly worked out on paper. Wicker is holding the source volume, the old black copy of *Dracula*, open at the page, closed over his finger. He holds it like a man who's been handed a baby by an enemy. Serenity is studying her map.

It's been thirteen days since the East Stacks. She's gone back to her work. She's gone back to toast. She's lost no weight in the face and gained no softness, and on her neck, above the collar, there's a thin line that isn't quite scar and isn't quite not. She looks up from her map, and across the hall at the tower, and the corner of her mouth goes in.

"I'm coming," she says.

"I was about to ask," says Permancer.

"You're very slow."

"I'm very thorough."

"That's what I said."

She folds the map into her repaired case. It's the mended one, with the small crooked clasp. I watch the clasp click shut under her thumb, a clean small *snick*, and I watch Wicker, across the hall, watch it happen. He watches it the way you'd watch a bridge you've built take weight for the first time.

She catches him looking.

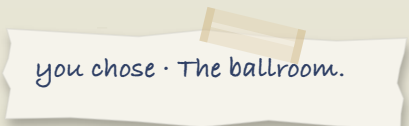
She doesn't smile. She doesn't scowl. She gives him a small, level nod,

just a fraction of an inch, the kind you give to a stranger who's held a door. Then she goes ahead.

Permancer counts us at the doorway. He counts twice, now. He's started to count a third time, and he stops himself, and just holds the bookmark a moment longer than he needs to, and nobody says anything.

Inside, the stair turns into a corridor. It's a long one, lamplit, with a floor of old boards and, beyond a bend, three ways through.

I tie my ribbon to the doorframe behind us. It's the only thing I can do. It's the end I've got, and I leave it fluttering there like a flag on a very small ship, so that, whatever else happens, we'll be able to find the way out.



you chose · The ballroom.

The Wrong Castle

Dracula's waiting in the central hall.

It's a great high round room, built out of several different castles, and none of them has agreed to hold it up. The ceiling's from one place. The floor's from another. A fireplace in the north wall is blowing snow into the room, sideways, in long clean ribbons, and it's settling on the Count's coat. Above him, the stolen nursery window has swung in on its own wall, and is trying very hard to find morning.

"This is not my castle," he says.

He sounds, for the first time, uncertain. He sounds like a man standing in somebody else's kitchen.

"No," says Serenity. "These are everybody else's rooms."

She's got her map in both hands, and her chin up.

A door opens in the east wall, and through it there's a small boat in a great storm, the whole sea heaving past the frame. Permancer throws himself at the handle and drags it shut, and a quart of seawater goes through the gap and soaks him to the knees.

"You have damaged my source," says Dracula.

There's no heat in it. It's an accusation said very quietly, with a

certain regret, by a man who's found his house wrecked and isn't sure whose fault it is.

Permancer keeps both hands on the handle. He's wet and he's tired and for once he's not lecturing.

"We did," he says.

It's a big thing, to say. I feel it go through the room. Nobody's expecting it, least of all the Count.

Wicker's holding the source volume open. He's standing very still, his shoulders drawn in, looking down at the page. His own sentence is there, in his own hand. *For one sentence, let him choose the verb.* And under it, in a second hand, small and neat, one word:

FOLLOW.

"I thought—" Wicker begins.

Serenity waits. She doesn't help him. She just waits.

He looks at the map case, with its crooked clasp. At the bandage above it, half hidden by her collar. He looks, I think, at everything he's ever made go wrong.

"I wanted to see what would happen."

"You have," says Serenity.

It's not cruel. It's perfectly level. He takes it. He lowers his eyes to the page and, for the first time since the Jump, doesn't look away.

Then the wall splits.

It happens quietly. There's a long thin crack, as if a very big breath has been let out behind the plaster, and where the stone parts there's something white. It's a fold of paper. A single sheet, thin as a held breath, running up the wall like ivy.

I know that paper.

I'd know it in the dark. I'd know it from across the Labyrinth. It's the same stuff I'm made of: the same flax, the same lime, the same long slow soak in a vat. It's *paper*. It's a page. And there's a gap in the page, a narrow clean tear like the one in the corner of a bookplate, and cold air's coming through it, and through the cold I can *hear* something. It's very far off. It sounds like a cover being opened.

Serenity touches the fold with one finger. Her map pulls toward the gap in her hands, the whole sheet stretching toward it like a plant.

“His way back,” she says.

Permancer brings the bookmark near. Its ribbons lift, one by one, and reach across the hall toward the source volume in Wicker's hands, toward the tear in the wall, and, slowly, almost reluctantly, toward Serenity.

Penny's already got three cards out. She sets one beside each, with a click.

SOURCE. INVITATION. LIVING CLAIM.

Dracula watches her write. His face doesn't move.

Serenity looks at the third card. It lies on the flagstone by her foot, plain white, with her own name nowhere on it. Then she puts out her hand, flat, and covers it.

“That one's mine.”

Behind us, through the shut door, the sea knocks again.

CLASS

The Glint

Wing 4: The Glint Hall · Professor Wispwood · 11:00 a.m.

Light, today, in the form of one stubborn lamp. You were asked to make it say something kind. It said 'later'.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Waxing Gibbous · clear

WRITE HERE

What was the weather doing, and what was it doing to you?

FOUR THINGS FOUND IN THE MARGIN

Find four shapes hiding in this issue's margins. Draw one in each card, name it, and cut it loose if it behaves.

SPECIMEN 1: _____

NAME:

SPECIMEN 2: _____

NAME:

SPECIMEN 3: _____

NAME:

SPECIMEN 4: _____

NAME:

CUT ONLY THE DASHED LINES · They were loose already.

I left this side empty on purpose, so your marker can't come through and spoil anything.

CHAPTER THE SECOND

In which you learned the name of the bakery cat after work

Then it was Friday and the sky was grey.

Learned the name of the bakery cat after work.

The mirror said you looked like someone who had been listening to a long story and had just reached the good part.

It rained again right after.

You tried the thing from the Wayfinding class, mapping the street by smell, on the way home.

Bakery, then the laundrette (hot cotton), then the bins behind the chip shop, then nothing for a long stretch, then woodsmoke from somebody's chimney two roads over. You'd never have noticed the woodsmoke if you hadn't been playing. You stood at the corner for a while just breathing it in like a weirdo. You think that's what this whole Book is for, honestly. Making you stand on corners. 21 days ago: The man at the bakery remembered you like the end piece.

Rooms that belong in other books lean in at the windows to see how the Academy does things.

I'm practising being quiet. I'm bad at it.

AN ENCHANTMENT

**Mirror, Mirror***6:00 p.m.*

The mirror said you looked like someone who had been listening to a long story and had just reached the good part.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Waxing Gibbous · cloud · wind

WRITE HERE

What did you eat, and was it any good?

CHAPTER THE THIRD

In which you oiled the squeaky kitchen door late at night

On Saturday there was a full moon and the sky was clear.

Oiled the squeaky kitchen door late at night. The kitchen smelled of three different days at once and was fond of all of them.

The kettle had been working up to it for years. Tuesday, it said, in a small steam voice, and nothing else. So on Tuesday nothing was done about anything, and it was a very good day.

Shirley said it was typical of you.

Counted the steps to the post box at Amanda's. Nobody else noticed. The river, going gold.

15 days ago: Shirley said it was typical of you.

Somebody is playing a slow tune on a harpsichord in a room that isn't on the map. The Academy hums along and loses its place.

I'm teaching myself to whistle. I haven't got the lips for it and I'm doing it anyway.

ILLUMINATED



Two-person portrait at the waterfront

A STORY THE BOOK TOLD

What the Kettle Said

The kettle had been working up to it for years. Tuesday, it said, in a small steam voice, and nothing else.

So on Tuesday nothing was done about anything, and it was a very good day.

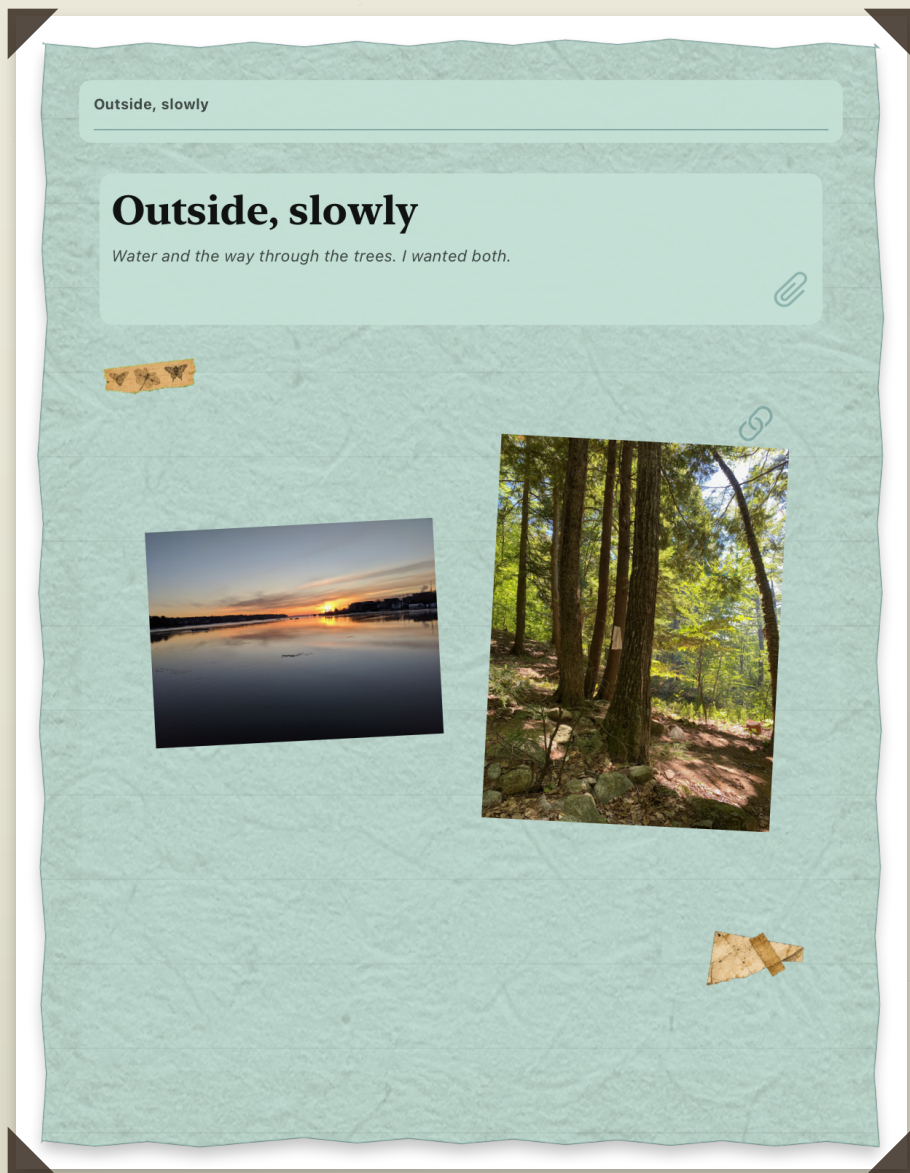
THE SKY THAT DAY

Full Moon · clear · wind

WRITE HERE

What did your hands do today?

FROM YOUR SCRAPBOOK



Outside, slowly · made at 8:00 p.m.

Water and the way through the trees. I wanted both.

CHAPTER THE FOURTH

In which you wore odd socks all day at the library

Sunday came next and the sky was raining.

Wore odd socks all day at the library.

Where Things Are Now

If one column gets read this week, make it this one. The Academy has company. A composite castle has grown through the East Stacks, which remain shut.

Sat with Amanda while she waited for news by the river.

The radio was playing something old. Tidied the shelf of things you never use on your lunch break. You didn't take a photo, on purpose. 18 days ago: You told Amanda about it later.

There's a stair between the supper tables. I've caught a loose moon in my ribbon. We need to get these rooms home before the rest of the library follows them out.

Tonight I'm holding the pen steady.

And in your own words:

9:00 a.m.

Wore odd socks all day at the library. I laughed out loud on my own.

CLASS

Quiet Hours*The Walled Garden · Professor Momort · 11:00 a.m.*

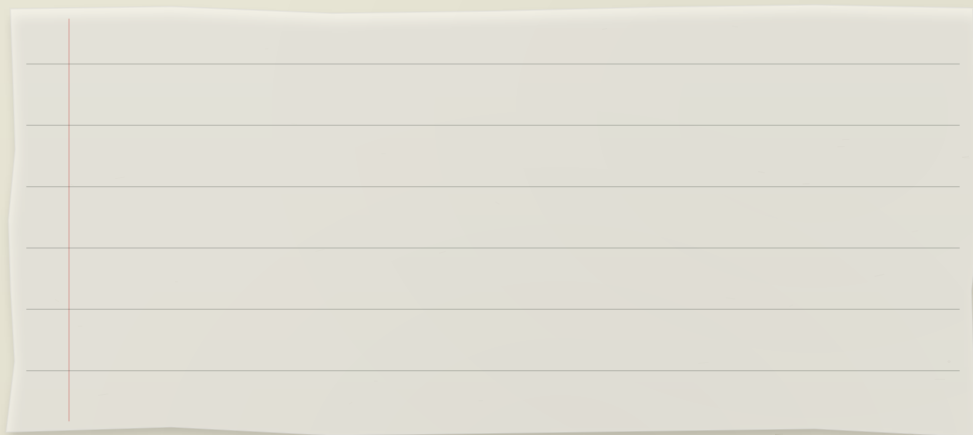
Ten minutes in the garden with nothing to do. You counted eleven kinds of green and one of grey.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Full Moon · rain

WRITE HERE

Leave a note for the person you will be next week.



CHAPTER THE FIFTH

In which you tried a new route to work on the way home

Then it was Monday and the sky was clear.

Tried a new route to work on the way home.

I have been meaning to write, which is a thing people say when they mean they have been avoiding the pen. The truth is simpler: you were in the corridor on Tuesday, looking at the window as if it had said something, and I didn't ask what. I regret that.

It made you late, which was fine.

19 days ago: Tried a new route to work at the library.

A drawbridge has come down across the Quillquarium. It's polite, and it creaks.

I can do half a whistle. It sounds like a kettle thinking.

A LETTER FROM PENNY BLACKLETTER

A letter from Penny Blackletter

I have been meaning to write, which is a thing people say when they mean they have been avoiding the pen. The truth is simpler: you were in the corridor on Tuesday, looking at the window as if it had said something, and I did not ask what. I regret that. So I am asking now, on paper, where I cannot see your face change.

What did it say?

— Penny Blackletter

ILLUMINATED



Person holding a rabbit

PINNED TO THE DAY

◦ Ink for Today · 9:00 a.m.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Full Moon · clear

WRITE HERE

Where did you go today that you didn't have to?

FROM YOUR SCRAPBOOK

These ones stay

These ones stay

Together by the water. Together with the animals.



These ones stay · made at 8:00 p.m.

Together by the water. Together with the animals.

CHAPTER THE SIXTH

In which a few small things were kept

On Tuesday there was a full moon.

That you missed writing in here on the two days you didn't.

I've caught a loose moon in my ribbon. It's heavier than it looks, and it hums.

The lamps whistled back. Or the draught did. We've agreed it was the lamps.

ILLUMINATED



Two-person portrait by the sea at sunset

CHAPTER THE SEVENTH

In which a few small things were kept · Wednesday

And then it was Wednesday. This is the last page I have from that week.

I did a whole whistle. It was one note. It was a good note.

CLUB

**The Compass Society**

7:00 p.m.

The society walked the school's perimeter and wrote down everything that had changed since September. Seventeen things. One was you.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Waning Gibbous

WRITE HERE

What are you looking forward to?

CHAPTER THE EIGHTH

In which _____

This one is yours to write. Put down the next thing that happens, in your own hand, and show me when you're done. I want to read it.

A large sheet of white paper with horizontal grey lines and a vertical red margin line on the left side, intended for writing.

I don't want this part falling out when I shut.

On Tuesday, you wrote:

"That I missed writing in here on the two days I didn't."

I can close my covers now. This part is kept.

The End

OF THIS WEEK

7 nights braided · 2 scenes read · 225 of your own words



The Tale of Your Week · Issue No. 4 · Every week of October is gathered in October's book · Made with ReEnchanted